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Get Clicked



112 Bookworm Or
Veteran?

Digital Business

How Technology Can Help Your Organisation

Smart SoHo

Learning To Share

Your Internet connection,
that is...

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Whatever the nature of your business, whether you have a three person team or 30,000, if you've got computers in your office, you're going to need a proxy server. Now larger businesses need something that can handle much more traffic, and we've earlier recommended Squid on a Linux server for them. However, smaller businesses (between 2 and 30 computers) might not have the free hardware or expertise to install and maintain Squid.

Most often, SoHo businesses need something Windows-based—a tool that's easily installed and just as easy to maintain. This is because most SoHo businesses cannot spare a computer, so the proxy server machine is quite simply just another computer on the network that the person with the Internet connection uses. Now Windows can also share a connection over the Network, but it does nothing else. The Windows Internet Connection Sharing Wizard will do nothing more than give all network computers access to your Net pipe, which will result in slow surfing speeds for everyone.

Proxy server software do not just share Net connections; they also cache files to save bandwidth, act as a firewall, put restrictions on content, and much more. So how does one go about choosing a good proxy server? The first step is to look for the following features:

- ▣ **The ability to run as a service:** You don't want everyone in your office getting disconnected from the Net just because someone accidentally closed the proxy server window.
- ▣ **Caching:** A proxy server that doesn't cache is just useless; caching helps save bandwidth and speed up the browsing experience.

- ▣ **User lists:** In order to make sure that no unauthorised people are using your Internet connection, you need to be able to give access to only specified users, with authentication.
- ▣ **Logging:** You need to keep an eye on what people in your company are using the Net for; to make sure they aren't misusing privileges.
- ▣ **Bandwidth controls and monitors:** These will help ensure that people don't overuse

Adding users to Proxy+

The Access List lets you control your proxy server